

Lustre

A transformer-coupled console summing mixer in the spirit of the silky late-80s British desks.



Overview

Lustre sums up to eight stereo stems through the bus of a transformer-coupled console from the late 80s: smooth, wide and expensive-sounding, with weight in the low mids and a top end that never bites.

The transformer works on the low mids (roughly 60 - 400 Hz). DENSITY sets how hard the iron is driven there, COLOUR chooses the character of the harmonics (even and round, or odd and firm), and a light touch of full-band density sits on top. WEIGHT and AIR add the console's low-mid body and a silky lift at the very top.

With the TRANSFORMER switched out, Lustre is a clean summing mixer with level, pan, solo and mute for each stem.

Reach for it for

- Summing stems or groups through one console-style bus
- Adding warmth and low-mid weight without dulling the top
- A smooth, open top end on a whole mix (AIR)
- Choosing between rounder (even) and firmer (odd) harmonic colour
- Quick stem balancing with solo and mute in one place

Setting up the routing in REAPER

1. Create a mix bus track and put Lustre on it. Open the track's ROUTE window and set Track channels to 16.
2. Channels 1/2 are STEM 1: whatever plays on the bus track itself (or is sent to it on 1/2).
3. On each other stem track, add a send to the bus track and pick a different destination channel pair for each: stem 2 on 3/4, stem 3 on 5/6, stem 4 on 7/8, stem 5 on 9/10, stem 6 on 11/12, stem 7 on 13/14, stem 8 on 15/16.
4. Turn off the master send on every stem track, so the stems are heard only through Lustre (otherwise you hear them twice).
5. The mix leaves on channels 1/2, so leave the bus track's master send on. The light under each stem's number glows when signal arrives.

Controls

Stems

Eight channel strips. The channel pair is printed under each name (1-2 up to 15-16).

Name	Click the name at the top of a strip and type (up to 16 characters, e.g. Drums). Enter keeps it, Escape cancels, an empty name goes back to the number. The names are saved with the project.
Signal light	Glow green when audio arrives on that stem and the stem is being heard (not muted, not left out by a solo, level not OFF).
PAN	Balance between left and right, from L100 through C to R100. Turning towards one side turns the other side down; the centre leaves both at full level.
LEVEL	The stem's level, from OFF (fully left, -60 dB) to +10 dB; 0 dB by default.
SOLO	Solo in place. Any number of stems can be soloed at once; while anything is soloed, only the soloed stems are heard.

MUTE

Silences the stem. A muted stem stays muted even when it is soloed.

Master

VU meters (L / R)

The output level of the mix.

DRIVE

The level into the bus and its transformers, -6 to +12 dB. It is level-matched: it changes how hard the iron works, not the volume.

DENSITY

How hard the transformer iron works, 0 to 100 (30 by default). The saturation is concentrated in the low mids, roughly 60 - 400 Hz, with a gentle touch of density across the whole band.

COLOUR

The character of the harmonics the iron adds. Left (EVEN) favours the 2nd harmonic: rounder and warmer. Right (ODD) favours the 3rd: firmer and more forward. The centre (BLEND) is the balanced mix.

AIR

A broad, silky lift at the very top (a shelf around 12 kHz), 0 to +6 dB.

WEIGHT

The transformer's low-mid weight: a broad lift around 180 Hz, 0 to +4 dB.

MASTER

The final level of the mix, from OFF (fully left, -60 dB) to +10 dB.

TRANSFORMER

In (lit, the default): the console's colour - DRIVE, DENSITY, COLOUR, WEIGHT and AIR all work, and the label reads TRANSFORMER-COUPLED BUS. Out: a straight, clean sum (STRAIGHT SUM); those five controls then have no effect.

The header

PRESETS

Opens the list of factory presets; the arrows beside it step through them, and the display shows the one in use (click it for the list too). The presets change only the bus controls; the last entry resets everything to the defaults.

S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Presets

Console Sheen	The default iron with a touch of air and weight.
Warm and Round (even)	4 dB of drive, more density, colour towards EVEN, extra air and weight.
Forward and Firm (odd)	4 dB of drive, more density, colour towards ODD for a firmer, more forward sound.
Driven Desk	8 dB of drive and heavy density, slightly even, with generous air and weight.
Open Top (air)	Light density with 3 dB of air for an open top end.
Low-Mid Weight	Even colour with 3 dB of weight and no air, for body in the low mids.
Straight Sum (transformer out)	Transformer out: a clean sum.
Reset all to defaults	Every control back to its starting value, including stem levels, pans, solos and mutes.

Tips

- The presets change only the bus settings; your stem levels, pans, solos and mutes are left alone (except Reset).
- Because DRIVE is level-matched, you can sweep it freely and judge the colour without being fooled by a jump in level.

- Try COLOUR towards EVEN on dense rock or pop mixes that feel hard, and towards ODD on mixes that need more definition.
- Toggle TRANSFORMER to compare the console colour against a clean sum at the same balance.

File: gfx-lustre.jsfx